

31 How About Us Humans?

This book concludes with chapters about the most important topic: **people**. While GenAI is an asset, it's nothing without the people that direct it. Much has been written about AI's upside and its potential to alter or even displace jobs, and the overall effect on humanity. These chapters address both sides of the debate.

The intended reader for these chapters includes HR professionals, the executive suite, and anyone with a high emotional IQ with an interest in coworkers' sentiment or perceptions about AI.

Scary Headlines

AI and automation have the potential to significantly impact the economy and the job market. It's safe to assume that at some point, jobs or at least tasks **will** be significantly impacted.

Back in 2019, the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development made a bold forecast. Within 15 to 20 years, it predicted, new automation technologies were **likely to eliminate 14% of the world's jobs and radically transform another 32%**.¹ Those were sobering numbers, involving more than 1 billion people globally—and they hadn't even considered how quickly GenAI would emerge.

This has some leaders thinking, like Shopify's CEO², requiring hiring managers to ask, "**Can AI accomplish the task instead?**"³ They've famously done more with less, and expect AI to continue to reduce hiring needs.

While organizations are rarely attributing layoffs solely to AI, there are some, like Uber, who mention AI in their larger set of reasons. They did so in mid-2026, saying cuts to their community operations team were "to simplify operations, strengthen in-person collaboration and continue to embrace AI."⁴

In 2025, the AI labs themselves created the darkest headlines. Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei said that **AI could eliminate half of entry-level white-collar jobs** and potentially drive U.S. unemployment to 10%–20% within one to five years.⁵ OpenAI CEO Sam Altman chimed in by imagining “A world where **30 to 40% of the tasks that happen in the economy today get done by AI** in the not very distant future.”⁶

The tech giants’ PR departments seem to be working on their CEOs’ messaging, hopefully referencing balanced, independent research like the following.

Counter Arguments

The International Labour Organization’s concluded in 2025 that **while in four workers are in an occupation with some degree of GenAI exposure, most jobs are more likely to be transformed than made redundant.**⁷

An MIT Sloan study summarized that “AI’s impact is often on specific tasks **within jobs** rather than on whole occupations,” and that “**Exposure to AI is greatest in higher-paying roles that involve information processing and analysis.**”⁸

In his article “AI Won’t Replace Humans — But Humans with AI Will Replace Humans Without AI,” Harvard Professor Karim Lakhani points out a subtle point. The question *isn’t* where AI can be applied, but rather **where thinking is applied**, indicating the wide-ranging potential of AI across various business sectors.⁹

Even Microsoft’s **2025 research analyzing Copilot usage** found that jobs involving tasks like writing, coding, information gathering, and advising—especially in fields such as software development, administrative support, sales, and legal work—are most susceptible to AI assistance. However, the study emphasizes that **AI is more adept at performing individual tasks than replacing entire jobs.**¹⁰

Effects on Early Adopters

There is a growing amount of research on the downsides of early adopters using AI and experiencing “brain fry.” Some “Agent bosses” report longer hours and take less breaks for deep thought as they spend more of their time bot-sitting. Marketing, HR, operations, and engineering personnel are most at risk, according to the HBR surveys.¹¹

Another potential risk worth watching is when people use AI for personal support. If AI is easier and more friendly to talk with, then its users may turn to their colleagues less and less. HBR found that as employees turn to AI for career advice, emotional support, occasionally, friendship, some tend to feel lonely at work. This can lead to lower job satisfaction and eventual turnover.¹²

Recognizing these risks and designing guidelines for healthy use are new and emerging factors to watch for HR and Center of Excellence leaders.

Plan for the Unpredictable

While some jobs may be impacted, or even displaced by these technologies, it's safe to assume that new jobs will be created, as they were after previous industrial revolutions. That said, the newly created jobs will require different skills and knowledge than those that are displaced. The current and next generations of workers will be most impacted as labor markets, societal friction, and new jobs stabilize.

For now, AI is reshaping jobs faster than it is eliminating them, and organizations that systematically hire and upskill employees differently will outperform those that don't. At the same time, heavy users may be paying the price, even though they may feel like they're getting ahead.

How does an organization create a sustainable, satisfied employee base for the future? That's the subject of the next two chapters.

References and Resources

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- ¹¹ <https://www.cbsnews.com/news/is-ai-productivity-prompting-burnout-study-finds-new-pattern-of-ai-brain-fry/> and <https://hbr.org/2026/03/when-using-ai-leads-to-brain-fry>
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